WEIMAR AND NAZI GERMANY, 1918–1939

KEY TOPIC 2: HITLER'S RISE TO POWER, 1919–1933

Student Master Textbook • Core Knowledge, Disciplinary Enquiries & Archival Evidence



Berlin, July 1931: Desperate crowds gathered outside the Sparkasse der Stadt Berlin during the Great Depression banking collapse (*Bankenkrach*). The crash threw 6 million into unemployment and shattered faith in Weimar democracy. Historical Primary Photograph

OFFICIAL PEARSON EDEXCEL GCSE SPECIFICATION STRUCTURE & SYLLABUS MAPPING (OPTION 31: KT2)

Core syllabus coverage across all four key enquiries:

1. EARLY NSDAP DEVELOPMENT, 1919–22

- DAP origins under Anton Drexler; Hitler joins and transforms party through personal oratory.
- The 25-Point Programme (Feb 1920): antisemitism, anti-Versailles, and pan-German nationalism.
- Formation of the SA (Brownshirts) under Ernst Röhm; party newspaper and the swastika emblem.

2. MUNICH PUTSCH & LEAN YEARS, 1923–29

- Munich Putsch (Nov 1923): causes, events at Bürgerbräukeller, and military collapse.
- Landsberg imprisonment: trial as propaganda triumph, writing of *Mein Kampf*, and legal strategy.
- Party reorganisation: Bamberg Conference (1926), SS creation, and electoral failure (2.6% in 1928).

3. GROWTH IN NAZI SUPPORT, 1929–32

- Wall Street Crash (Oct 1929): 6 million unemployed, bank collapses, and middle-class ruin.
- Death of parliamentary democracy: Chancellor Brüning cuts welfare and rules by Article 48.
- Growth of KPD; Nazi appeal to middle classes, big business, and youth via negative cohesion.

4. HOW HITLER BECAME CHANCELLOR, 1932–33

- Electoral breakthroughs: 107 seats (1930), 230 seats (July 1932); presidential elections.
- Fall of Brüning and Schleicher; Franz von Papen's aristocratic "Cabinet of Barons".
- The "Backstairs Plot": Papen convinces Hindenburg to appoint Hitler Chancellor (30 Jan 1933).

KT2.1: The Early Development of the Nazi Party, 1919–1922

Key Enquiry: From the shadows: How did a tiny, obscure political group in a Munich beer hall transform into a highly organised and violent political machine under Adolf Hitler's early leadership? • *Sections 1 & 2: Context, Catalysts & Primary Evidence*

ACT 1 THE ORIGINS: ANTON DREXLER, THE DAP & HITLER'S ORATORY

[1.1] **The Foundation of the DAP & Hitler's Recruitment:** In January 1919, in the turbulent aftermath of the First World War, railway mechanic Anton Drexler founded the German Workers' Party (*Deutsche Arbeiterpartei*, DAP) in Munich. Bitterly opposing the Weimar Republic, the Treaty of Versailles, and Marxism, Drexler advocated an extreme blend of pan-German nationalism and working-class protectionism. In September 1919, the Bavarian army dispatched intelligence agent Adolf Hitler to spy on a DAP beer hall meeting. Impressed by Hitler's fiery interjection in a political debate, Drexler recruited him as the party's 55th member, quickly appointing him director of propaganda.

[1.2] **Hitler's Demagogic Star Power & Beer Hall Mass Rallies:** Hitler rapidly transformed the obscure fringe group through theatrical public speaking. Rehearsing gestures and dramatic pauses, he began speeches in a quiet conversational tone before building to a crescendo of fanatical rage. He offered simple, visceral scapegoats for Germany's post-war collapse: the 'November Criminals', communist traitors, and international Jewish finance. Drawing thousands of paying spectators into Munich beer halls, Hitler raised vital admission revenues, winning fierce personal loyalty and making himself indispensable to the party's survival.

[1.3] **Staging the Beer Hall Spectacle & The Bavarian Appeal:** Hitler perfected the theatrical staging of party meetings. Arriving deliberately late to build tension, he entered large beer halls flanked by swastika flags, martial music, and armed stewards. In the smoke-filled halls of Munich, Hitler tapped into deep Bavarian grievances: hatred of the socialist republic in Berlin, outrage over the Versailles "war guilt" clause, and fears of a Bolshevik revolution. His impassioned delivery and radical anti-establishment stance transformed the DAP from a tiny tavern debating circle into a magnet for embittered veterans and extreme nationalists.

SOURCE A POLICE INTELLIGENCE REPORT Munich, 15 February 1921

Bavarian Police Surveillance Report on Hitler's Early Speeches

> *"The speaker, Adolf Hitler, addressed an audience of over two thousand in the Bürgerbräukeller. He spoke with fanatical energy for two and a half hours, constantly whipping the crowd into frenzy over the 'November criminals', the Versailles treaty, and international Jewish finance... The applause was deafening. He possesses an extraordinary demagogic power over the uneducated masses."*

Confidential Bavarian political police dossier assessing Hitler's rapid emergence as the primary public draw and propaganda chief for the fledgling NSDAP in Munich.

HINGE QUESTION: *How does the police report explain Hitler's ability to transform a tiny fringe party into a mass movement in post-war Munich?*

ACT 2 THE 25-POINT PROGRAMME, REBRANDING & THE SA (1920–1921)

[2.1] **The 25-Point Programme & Party Rebranding:** In February 1920, Hitler and Drexler unveiled the 25-Point Programme at the Hofbräuhaus beer hall before two thousand supporters. Designed as a populist manifesto to recruit across social classes, it blended nationalist demands (revoking Versailles, uniting all Germans in a Greater Reich, denying Jews citizenship) with socialist appeals (abolishing unearned income, profit-sharing in heavy industry, expanding pensions). In August 1920, Hitler rebranded the party as the National Socialist German Workers' Party (*NSDAP*), adopting the swastika emblem and the newspaper *Völkischer Beobachter*.

[2.2] **The Führer Principle & Founding the Sturmabteilung (SA):** By July 1921, Hitler used his oratorical indispensability to confront Drexler. Threatening to resign, he forced the committee to grant him absolute dictatorial powers as sole Party Chairman (*Führer*). In August 1921, he organized the *Sturmabteilung* (SA, or 'Brownshirts') under Ernst Röhm. Recruited largely from ex-soldiers and demobilised Freikorps fighters, the SA served as a violent paramilitary squad tasked with protecting Nazi speakers, assaulting rival communist rallies, and terrorising political opponents through disciplined street violence.

[2.3] **The 1921 Führer Takeover & The Swastika Emblem:** To consolidate total personal control, Hitler resigned in July 1921, demanding absolute dictatorial authority as Party Chairman (*Führer*). Realizing the party would collapse without his star appeal, the committee capitulated, granting him supreme leadership. Hitler introduced military discipline, the Roman arm salute, and designed the party banner: a black hooked cross (*Hakenkreuz*) on a white circle surrounded by revolutionary red. With the SA terrorising political rivals, the rebranded NSDAP stood ready to launch its bid for state power.

SOURCE B FOUNDATIONAL MANIFESTO 24 February 1920

Points 1, 2, and 4 of the Nazi 25-Point Programme

> *"1. We demand the unification of all Germans in the Greater Germany on the basis of the right of self-determination of peoples.*
>
> *2. We demand equality of rights for the German people in respect to the other nations; revocation of the peace treaties of Versailles and St Germain.*
>
> *4. None but members of the nation may be citizens of the state. None but those of German blood, whatever their creed, may be members of the nation. No Jew, therefore, may be a member of the nation."*

Proclaimed by Adolf Hitler to over two thousand people at the Hofbräuhaus beer hall in Munich, establishing the core tenets of Nazi ideology: pan-German expansion, destruction of Versailles, and racial antisemitism.

HINGE QUESTION: *Did the 25-Point Programme represent a coherent political ideology, or a contradictory collection of populist grievances designed to attract maximum support?*

CORE DISCIPLINARY TERMINOLOGY • ENQUIRY 2.1

EDEXCEL PAPER 3 VOCABULARY

DAP
German Workers' Party founded by Anton Drexler in 1919; renamed NSDAP (Nazi Party) under Hitler in 1920.

25-POINT PROGRAMME
The founding political manifesto of the Nazi Party (Feb 1920) demanding revocation of Versailles and antisemitic citizenship.

STURMABTEILUNG (SA)
The paramilitary "Brownshirts" formed in 1921 under Ernst Röhm to protect Nazi meetings and intimidate political rivals.

FÜHRERPRINZIP
The "leader principle"; total dictatorial authority requiring absolute, unquestioning obedience from all subordinates.

KT2.1: The Early Development of the Nazi Party, 1919–1922

ACT 3 BLOOD AND IRON: THE PARAMILITARY MUSCLE OF THE SA

[3.1] Paramilitary Discipline & The Freikorps Recruits: Under the command of Captain Ernst Röhm, the *Sturmabteilung* (SA, or 'Brownshirts') underwent rapid expansion between 1921 and 1922. Recruited heavily from demobilized soldiers, unemployed youth, and violent Freikorps paramilitaries, the SA provided young men with military discipline, uniforms, free meals, and an outlet for violent anti-socialist hatred. By 1922, the SA operated as a private army of over 6,000 brawlers, marching in strict military formations and staging intimidating torchlight parades across Bavaria.

[3.2] Street Warfare & Intimidation as Political Theatre: The primary function of the SA was the violent monopolisation of public spaces. In November 1921, during the infamous 'Hofbräuhaus Battle', fifty SA stormtroopers assaulted hundreds of socialists attempting to disrupt a Hitler rally, beating them with beer mugs and table legs. However, recognizing that the SA retained strong personal loyalty to Röhm, Hitler established a dedicated personal bodyguard unit in 1923: the *Stosstrupp Adolf Hitler*, the forerunner of the SS. For Hitler, paramilitary violence was essential theatre: it created an aura of invincible power that appealed to Germans terrified of Bolshevik revolution.

MILITARY SURVEILLANCE REICHSWEHR INTELLIGENCE REPORT — September 1919

Captain Karl Mayr on Adolf Hitler's Oratorical Talent

"Hitler is a born popular speaker who, by his fanaticism and populist appeal in a mass gathering, unconditionally forces his listeners to his point of view... He spoke with extraordinary passion against the Versailles Diktat and Jewish Bolshevism, holding the entire tavern spellbound for over eighty minutes."

KEY HISTORICAL INDIVIDUAL 1884–1942



Anton Drexler
FOUNDER OF THE GERMAN WORKERS' PARTY (DAP) & EARLY NAZI PARTY MENTOR

Founded the nationalist German Workers' Party in Munich in January 1919, recruited Adolf Hitler as party member 555, and co-wrote the founding 25-Point Programme.

DECISIVE ACTIONS:

- Established the DAP in a Munich beer hall in January 1919, combining militant nationalism with anti-capitalist rhetoric.
- Collaborated with Adolf Hitler to author the party's 25-Point Programme, officially proclaimed on 24 February 1920.
- Ousted from party leadership in July 1921 when Hitler threatened to resign unless granted absolute dictatorial power (*Führerprinzip*).

ACT 4 HISTORICAL EVALUATION: A REGIONAL BAVARIAN FRINGE PARTY

[4.1] Regional Containment & The Bavarian Sanctuary: While the creation of the 25-Point Programme and the *Völkischer Beobachter* demonstrated remarkable zeal, the early Nazi Party remained strictly confined to Bavaria. In the aftermath of the 1919 Bavarian Soviet Republic, Munich had become an ultra-conservative, anti-socialist sanctuary ruled by right-wing Commissioner Gustav von Kahr. Under Kahr's protection, the Bavarian police and judiciary turned a blind eye to right-wing violence, shielding the NSDAP from federal intervention and allowing Hitler to operate with impunity.

[4.2] Bavarian Defiance & The 1922 Status: Following the June 1922 assassination of Foreign Minister Walther Rathenau, the Reichstag passed the Law for the Protection of the Republic, banning radical paramilitary groups. However, the Bavarian government openly defied Berlin, refusing to enforce the ban against the NSDAP. Despite having roughly 20,000 members and filling Munich beer halls, the NSDAP remained virtually unknown outside Bavaria. The party did not hold a single Reichstag seat, and industrial workers backed the SPD or KPD. Nevertheless, Hitler had built a disciplined machine that only awaited an economic crisis to break out nationally.

PARAMILITARY VIOLENCE: THE SA BROWNSHIRTS POLITICAL TERROR • 1921

The Sturmabteilung (SA) & Beer Hall Intimidation

Formed in August 1921 and led by hardened WWI veteran Ernst Röhm, the *Sturmabteilung* (SA or 'Brownshirts') served as the paramilitary enforcement arm of the Nazi Party. Composed largely of demobilised Freikorps soldiers and unemployed youth, the SA protected Nazi speakers at rallies while violently attacking political opponents, breaking up communist meetings, and terrorising Jewish businesses across Bavaria. By 1922, the SA numbered several thousand disciplined brawlers who provided the party with an imposing aura of military strength.

Violent Coercion: Paramilitary violence was not a byproduct of early Nazism but its central engine: it enabled Hitler to command Munich's public spaces and present the NSDAP as a militant barrier against communist revolution.

HISTORIOGRAPHICAL DEBATE THE EARLY NAZI PARTY: CHARISMATIC LEADER OR BAVARIAN CURIOSITY?

Interpretation A: Charismatic Dominance (Ian Kershaw)
"Without Hitler's extraordinary oratorical gifts and messianic self-belief, the DAP would have remained an obscure beer-hall sect. His magnetic voice transformed a provincial fringe into a militant political movement."

Interpretation B: Structural Fringe (Alan Bullock)
"In the early 1920s, the NSDAP was merely one of dozens of racist, antisemitic völkisch cliques in Munich. It survived solely because right-wing Bavarian authorities shielded it from Berlin's republican bans."

KEY CHRONOLOGY • FOUR CAUSAL TURNING POINTS ENQUIRY 2.1 SEQUENCE

5 Jan 1919 • DAP Founded in Munich
Anton Drexler forms the German Workers' Party; Hitler is dispatched by army intelligence and joins as member 55.

24 Feb 1920 • The 25-Point Programme
Hitler announces the manifesto at the Hofbräuhaus, revoking Versailles and demanding a Greater German Reich.

29 Jul 1921 • Hitler Becomes Führer
Hitler ousts Drexler, demanding absolute dictatorial control over the party; designs swastika emblem and banner.

Aug 1921 • Founding of the SA
Ernst Röhm organizes the Brownshirts (*Sturmabteilung*), creating a private paramilitary army to control streets.

EDEXCEL PAPER 3 EXAMINATION STRATEGY • SECTION A QUESTION 1 • 4 MARKS • 5 MINS

Exam Challenge: Give two things you can infer from Source A about the core beliefs of the Nazi Party in 1920. [4 marks]

Specification Technique: State 2 distinct historical inferences directly supported by explicit quotes or visual evidence from Source A. GRADE 9 ACCURACY

KT2.2: The Munich Putsch and the Lean Years, 1923–1929

Key Enquiry: A spectacular failure or a political masterstroke: How did Hitler use the disaster of the Munich Putsch to completely rebuild the Nazi Party during its 'lean years'? • *Sections 1 & 2: Context, Catalysts & Primary Evidence*

ACT 1 PISTOL SHOTS IN THE BÜRGERBRÄUKELLER: VON KAHR HELD AT GUNPOINT IN THE MUNICH PUTSCH (8 NOV 1923)

[1.1] In autumn 1923, hyperinflation peaked and Chancellor Stresemann ended passive resistance in the Ruhr, infuriating right-wing Bavarian nationalists. Convinced the Weimar Republic was disintegrating, Hitler resolved to seize national power. Inspired by Benito Mussolini's 1922 "March on Rome" and securing the military prestige of First World War hero **General Ludendorff** (General Erich Ludendorff), Hitler plotted an armed coup to overthrow both the Bavarian government and the national republic in Berlin.

[1.2] On the evening of 8 November 1923, Bavarian State Commissioner Gustav von Kahr was addressing 3,000 businessmen in the *Bürgerbräukeller* in Munich. At 8:30 PM, 600 armed SA men surrounded the hall. Hitler burst in, fired a pistol shot into the ceiling, and announced the launch of the **Munich Putsch**: *"The national revolution has broken out! The Bavarian and Berlin governments are deposed!"* In a side room, Hitler held Kahr, army commander Lossow, and police chief Seisser at gunpoint until they reluctantly promised support.

ACT 2 BLOODSHED AT THE FELDHERRNHALLE: BAVARIAN POLICE FIRE AND THE COLLAPSE OF THE COUP (9 NOV 1923)

[2.1] Hitler's triumph evaporated overnight. Once released from the beer cellar, Kahr and Lossow repudiated their coerced promises and summoned army and state police reinforcements. Meanwhile, Ernst Röhm's SA stormtroopers were surrounded inside the War Ministry. Desperate to regain momentum, Hitler and **General Ludendorff** led 2,000 armed Nazis through Munich at noon on 9 November, marching toward the Bavarian War Ministry hoping the police would refuse to fire on a legendary wartime commander.

[2.2] At the *Feldherrnhalle* monument, the column was confronted by a cordon of armed state police. A shootout erupted: sixteen Nazis and four police officers were killed in minutes. General Ludendorff marched straight through the gunfire unharmed and was arrested, while Hitler dislocated his shoulder diving for cover and fled in a yellow car. Two days later, Hitler was arrested hiding in the attic of a villa outside Munich; the armed putsch had collapsed in humiliating failure.

[3.1] In February 1924, Hitler, Ludendorff, and eight conspirators stood trial for high treason in Munich (**Source A**). Facing execution or life imprisonment, Hitler turned the courtroom into a propaganda triumph. Sympathetic right-wing judges granted him unlimited speaking time. Hitler shamelessly admitted his actions, portraying himself as a selfless patriot fighting to overthrow the "November Criminals," winning front-page headlines across Germany.

[3.2] General Ludendorff was acquitted, while Hitler received the minimum sentence of five years with early parole eligibility. Sent to comfortable confinement in **Landsberg Prison** (Landsberg Fortress), Hitler served just nine months. There, he dictated ***Mein Kampf*** ('My Struggle') to Rudolf Hess (**Source B**), setting out his core ideology: Aryan racial supremacy, anti-Semitism, anti-communism, and *Lebensraum* (living space in the East). Most importantly, the failed coup convinced Hitler that power could not be seized by armed revolt, but must be won legally through democratic elections.

SOURCE A ARCHIVAL PHOTOGRAPH — February 1924

Adolf Hitler, General Ludendorff, and Co-Defendants on Trial for Treason



Hitler and his fellow Munich Putsch conspirators photographed outside the Munich courtroom. General Ludendorff stands centrally in imperial uniform, while Hitler wears civilian dress with an Iron Cross, projecting patriotic legitimacy.

HINGE QUESTION: *Why did the conservative Bavarian judges allow Hitler to turn a trial for armed treason into a nationwide nationalist propaganda showcase?*

SOURCE B IDEOLOGICAL MANIFESTO — Landsberg Prison, 1924

Hitler on Political Struggle in Mein Kampf

> *"The receptive ability of the masses is very restricted, and their understanding feeble; on the other hand, they quickly forget. Such being the case, all effective propaganda must be confined to very few points and must harp on these in slogans until the last member of the public understands what you want him to understand... Blood mixing and the resultant drop in the racial level is the sole cause of the dying out of old cultures."*

Written while serving his sentence in Landsberg Fortress, Mein Kampf combined extreme racial Social Darwinism with a cynical, highly calculated theory of mass political propaganda.

HINGE QUESTION: *Did Mein Kampf provide a rigid masterplan for future Nazi policy, or merely reflect Hitler's raw ideological prejudices?*

CORE DISCIPLINARY TERMINOLOGY • ENQUIRY 2.2 — EDEXCEL PAPER 3 VOCABULARY

MUNICH PUTSCH (1923)
Failed armed coup launched by Hitler and Ludendorff on 8–9 Nov 1923 attempting to overthrow the Weimar government.

MEIN KAMPF
"My Struggle"; Hitler's autobiographical manifesto written in Landsberg Prison outlining Aryan supremacy and Lebensraum.

BAMBERG CONFERENCE (1926)
Party gathering where Hitler crushed the socialist wing led by Strasser and cemented absolute ideological control.

LEGAL STRATEGY
Hitler's post-putsch decision to abandon armed rebellion and win power legally by winning democratic elections.

KT2.2: The Munich Putsch and the Lean Years, 1923–1929

ACT 3 THE BAMBERG CONFERENCE: CRUSHING STRASSER'S LEFT WING AND PLEDGING THE LEGAL PATH TO POWER (1925–1926)

[4.1] Released from Landsberg Prison in December 1924, Hitler found the Nazi Party banned, bankrupt, and fractured. In February 1925, he persuaded the Bavarian government to lift the ban, promising strict constitutional legality. Hitler then launched a sweeping **party reorganisation**, creating central departments for youth, women, and students, dividing Germany into thirty-five regional party districts (*Gaue*) commanded by loyal *Gauleiter* directly appointed by Hitler.

[4.2] In February 1926, Hitler convened the decisive **Bamberg Conference of 1926** in northern Bavaria to crush an internal ideological split. The northern party wing, led by Gregor Strasser and Joseph Goebbels, advocated radical anti-capitalist, socialist policies that alarmed southern business donors. In a five-hour address, Hitler crushed the socialist faction, won Goebbels to his side, and reaffirmed the 25-Point Programme as unalterable, cementing the *Führerprinzip* across all party branches.

[3.2] **Paramilitary Reorganisation: Founding the SS and Hitler Youth:** Following the Bamberg Conference of February 1926, Hitler consolidated his absolute authority. In 1925, he established the *Schutzstaffel* (SS) as an elite, fanatically obedient black-shirted personal bodyguard to counterbalance the unruly SA. In 1926, the party created the Hitler Youth (*Hitlerjugend*) to recruit teenage boys, alongside professional leagues for doctors, lawyers, and teachers. Recognizing the power of modern propaganda, Hitler appointed Dr Joseph Goebbels as Gauleiter of Berlin in 1926, tasking him with capturing the working-class capital through relentless provocation.

COURTROOM TESTIMONY CLOSING TRIAL SPEECH — 27 March 1924

Adolf Hitler at his Trial for High Treason in Munich

"You may pronounce us guilty a thousand times over, but the goddess of the eternal court of history will smile and tear to tatters the brief of the state prosecutor and the sentence of this court. For she acquits us! The army we have formed is growing day by day... from our dead comrades a new Germany shall arise!"

KEY HISTORICAL INDIVIDUAL — 1865–1937



General Erich Ludendorff
IMPERIAL QUARTERMASTER GENERAL & NATIONALIST LEADER OF THE MUNICH PUTSCH

Celebrated First World War commander who lent immense national prestige to Hitler's 1923 putsch, marching at the front of the column.

DECISIVE ACTIONS:

- Promoted the 'stab-in-the-back' myth after WWI, blaming democratic politicians for defeat.
- Joined Hitler in the Bürgerbräukeller on 8 November 1923, coercing Bavarian leaders at gunpoint.
- Marched unarmed through police fire at the Feldherrnhalle; acquitted by sympathetic right-wing judges.

ACT 4 THE ELECTORAL WILDERNESS: 2.6% OF THE REICHSTAG VOTE IN THE GOLDEN TWENTIES (MAY 1928)

[5.1] Despite party reorganisation, the primary **reasons for limited support for the Nazi Party, 1924–28** lay in Weimar's economic and political stabilization. Stresemann's successful introduction of the Rentenmark, the Dawes Plan loans, rising real wages, and new unemployment insurance created general prosperity. Furthermore, international diplomatic breakthroughs like the Locarno Pact and joining the League of Nations restored national pride. In an era of peace, democracy, and economic recovery, extremist messages found little public appeal.

[5.2] In the **May 1928 election** (the Reichstag election of May 1928), the Nazi Party suffered a humiliating defeat, polling just **2.6% of the vote** and winning only twelve seats. Yet behind this electoral failure, Hitler had built a disciplined nationwide party apparatus of 100,000 trained activists, skilled public speakers, and the elite **Schutzstaffel (SS)** bodyguard. When the economic crash arrived in 1929, the party was primed to exploit national panic.

STRATEGIC PIVOT: THE LEGAL ROAD TO POWER — PARTY REORGANISATION • 1924–1928

The 'Legal Strategy' & Party Restructuring

In Landsberg Prison, Hitler dictated *Mein Kampf* and reached a crucial strategic realization: armed insurrection was impossible. Instead, the Nazis had to destroy democracy from within: "If outvoting them takes longer than outshooting them, the results are guaranteed by their own constitution." Hitler refounded the party in 1925, divided Germany into 35 administrative regions (*Gaue*) under loyal *Gauleiters*, and established affiliate bodies including the SS and Hitler Youth.

The Structural Springboard: Although the Nazis won only 12 seats (2.6%) in 1928, this nationwide organizational machinery gave them an instantly deployable propaganda network when crisis struck in 1929.

HISTORIOGRAPHICAL DEBATE — THE LEAN YEARS (1924–1929): WASTELAND OR ESSENTIAL FOUNDATION?

Interpretation A: Essential Reorganisation (Dietrich Orlow)
"The lean years were decisive. Under the guise of legality, Hitler constructed a shadow bureaucracy and disciplined Gauleiters that made subsequent triumph possible."

Interpretation B: Irrelevant Fringe (Richard J. Evans)
"By 1928, the Nazi Party was a bankrupt, squabbling extremist sect rejected by 97.4% of voters. Without the Depression, it would have dissolved into total obscurity."

KEY CHRONOLOGY • FOUR CAUSAL TURNING POINTS — ENQUIRY 2.2 SEQUENCE

8–9 Nov 1923 • The Munich Beer Hall Putsch
Hitler hijacks Kahr's meeting and marches on Munich; police fire kills 16 Nazis and the coup collapses.

Feb–Apr 1924 • The Landsberg Trial
Hitler turns his treason trial into a national propaganda triumph; sentenced to 5 years, serves only 9 months.

18 Jul 1925 • Publication of Mein Kampf
Volume 1 of Hitler's manifesto is published, setting out racial hierarchy, anti-Semitism, and *Lebensraum*.

14 Feb 1926 • The Bamberg Conference
Hitler re-establishes total authority over northern socialist rivals, cementing the unquestioned *Führerprinzip*.

EDEXCEL PAPER 3 EXAMINATION STRATEGY • SECTION A — QUESTION 2 • 12 MARKS • 18 MINS

Exam Challenge: Explain why the Nazi Party experienced the 'Lean Years' between 1924 and 1928. [12 marks]

Specification Stimulus: (1) Stresemann's economic policies • (2) Hitler's reorganization of the party • *Deploy 3 PEEL paragraphs with precise causal evidence.* — **GRADE 9 CAUSATION**

KT2.3: The Growth of Nazi Support, 1929–1932

Key Enquiry: The shattered Republic: How did the economic earthquake of the Great Depression destroy Weimar democracy and propel Adolf Hitler from the political fringes to the brink of power? • *Sections 1 & 2: Context, Catalysts & Primary Evidence*

ACT 1 BLACK THURSDAY IN NEW YORK: THE WALL STREET CRASH AND THE RECALL OF AMERICAN LOANS (OCT 1929)

[1.1] On 29 October 1929, the Wall Street Crash struck the United States, instantly triggering the worldwide Great Depression. Because Stresemann's economic recovery had been funded by short-term American loans under the Dawes Plan, the German economy was hit harder than any other in Europe as American banks abruptly recalled billions of marks in credit.

[1.2] Deprived of financial liquidity, German industry collapsed: industrial output plunged by 40%, exports fell by 61%, and major banks went bankrupt. The most devastating social consequence was the rapid **growth of unemployment**, with joblessness soaring from 1.3 million in 1929 to over 3 million in 1930, devastating families and driving millions of voters toward political extremism.

[1.2] **The Banking Crisis & Industrial Collapse:** The disaster deepened in 1931 when Austria's Creditanstalt and Germany's Danat Bank failed, forcing Chancellor Brüning to declare a nationwide bank holiday. Over 50,000 German businesses went bankrupt between 1930 and 1932. Industrial production plunged by 42%, while middle-class savers saw their deposits frozen once again. Desperate families lined the streets of major cities, where over 600,000 people were registered homeless.

[1.3] **The Human Cost: Shantytowns, Breadlines and Social Despair:** By 1932, over 6 million Germans were officially registered as unemployed, though real numbers exceeded 8 million when uncounted women and youths were included. In Berlin, thousands of evicted families lived in squalid shantytowns named 'Tent Cities' (*Zeltstädte*). Impoverished war veterans and fathers queued for hours outside municipal soup kitchens, wearing cardboard placards that read: "I will take any work, even the hardest." This pervasive poverty shattered faith in democracy.

SOURCE A ELECTION PROPAGANDA POSTER — 1932 Presidential Election

Our Last Hope: Hitler (Unsere letzte Hoffnung: Hitler)



Designed by artist Mjölnir (Hans Schweitzer) for the 1932 elections, showing grim, impoverished faces of unemployed workers, mothers, and veterans looking up toward Hitler as their solitary saviour from economic ruin.

HINGE QUESTION: *Why was this visual imagery extraordinarily effective at winning over voters who had never previously supported extreme nationalism?*

ACT 2 THE 'HUNGER CHANCELLOR': HEINRICH BRÜNING, ARTICLE 48 AND SIX MILLION JOBLESS (1930–1932)

[2.1] By the winter of 1932, the **growth of unemployment** reached catastrophic dimensions: over **6 million registered jobless**—one in three German workers (**Source A**). Millions of desperate men queued outside municipal labour exchanges (*Arbeitsämter*), slept in soup kitchens, or stood on street corners. In March 1930, the democratic coalition government collapsed over whether to raise unemployment contributions, ending parliamentary democracy in the Weimar Republic.

[2.2] President Hindenburg appointed Centre Party politician **Heinrich Brüning** as Chancellor. Lacking a Reichstag majority, Brüning enacted harsh deflationary welfare cuts, slashing civil servant pay, cutting pensions, and reducing unemployment relief, earning the hatred of workers as the **"Hunger Chancellor."** When the Reichstag rejected his budget, Brüning dissolved parliament and ruled entirely by presidential emergency decree under **Article 48**, fatally normalizing authoritarian rule.

[3.1] Economic misery led to the dramatic growth of support for the **Communist Party (KPD)**, which climbed to 100 Reichstag seats and 17% of the vote by late 1932. Communist paramilitaries fought daily street battles erupting in street violence against the Nazi SA across industrial cities like Berlin and Hamburg, raising fears of an imminent Bolshevik revolution.

[3.2] Fear of communism terrified the German middle classes (*Mittelstand*), small businessmen, shopkeepers, and wealthy landowners (Junkers). Haunted by memories of the 1917 Russian Revolution and hyperinflation in 1923, they feared communists would confiscate private property and abolish religion. Hitler expertly exploited this panic, presenting the Nazi Party as Germany's sole protective bulwark against communist destruction.

SOURCE B OFFICIAL STATISTICAL RECORD — Statistical Office of the German Reich

Reichstag Election Results & German Unemployment (1928–1932)

"May 1928: 1.4 million unemployed • Nazi vote: 2.6% (12 seats)
September 1930: 3.0 million unemployed • Nazi vote: 18.3% (107 seats)
July 1932: 5.4 million unemployed • Nazi vote: 37.3% (230 seats)
November 1932: 5.1 million unemployed • Nazi vote: 33.1% (196 seats)
Communist (KPD) vote surged concurrently from 54 seats in 1928 to 100 seats in November 1932."

Official Reich statistics demonstrating the direct mathematical correlation between rising unemployment following the Wall Street Crash and the dramatic electoral surge of extremist parties.

HINGE QUESTION: *Does the November 1932 decline in Nazi votes demonstrate that the party had already passed its electoral peak before Hitler became Chancellor?*

CORE DISCIPLINARY TERMINOLOGY • ENQUIRY 2.3 — EDEXCEL PAPER 3 VOCABULARY

WALL STREET CRASH (1929)
Catastrophic US stock market collapse in October 1929, triggering the global Great Depression and German economic ruin.

HEINRICH BRÜNING
Weimar Chancellor (1930–32) whose deflationary wage and benefit cuts earned him the label "the Hunger Chancellor".

NEGATIVE COHESION
Voters uniting around shared hatreds (fear of communism, disgust with Weimar) rather than agreement on Nazi policies.

KPD
The German Communist Party, whose surging support terrified middle-class Germans and drove them toward the Nazis.

KT2.3: The Growth of Nazi Support, 1929–1932

ACT 3 PROPAGANDA BY AIR AND LOUDSPEAKER: JOSEPH GOEBBELS PACKAGES THE HITLER CULT (1930–1932)

[4.1] Key **reasons for the growth in support for the Nazi Party** included the powerful **appeal of Hitler and the Nazis**, who presented an image of dynamic national revival. The charismatic appeal of Hitler—promoted as a classless national savior—electrified mass rallies with promises to restore employment, crush communism, and tear up the hated Treaty of Versailles.

[4.2] Furthermore, the revolutionary **effects of propaganda** organized by Joseph Goebbels outclassed all political rivals. Goebbels flooded cities with uniform posters promising "Work and Bread" (*Arbeit und Brot*), utilized radio broadcasts, and pioneered modern campaign travel. In his 1932 "Hitler Over Germany" campaign, Hitler flew by chartered passenger aeroplane to speak in four or five major cities in a single day (**Source B**), projecting futuristic energy.

CONTEMPORARY EYE-WITNESS JOURNALISTIC REPORT Winter 1931–1932

Heinrich Hauser on Unemployment in Berlin

"An almost unbroken chain of men stood in queues stretching for hundreds of yards in the freezing slush outside the municipal welfare office. Their clothes were threadbare; they stood silently, staring at the pavement with hollow eyes. For these millions of desperate men, Weimar democracy has brought only starvation, eviction, and disgrace."

KEY HISTORICAL INDIVIDUAL 1885–1970



Heinrich Brüning

CHANCELLOR OF GERMANY (1930–1932) & LEADER OF THE CENTRE PARTY

Dismantled parliamentary democracy by ruling through Article 48 emergency decrees; his ruthless austerity policies earned him the hated title of the "Hunger Chancellor".

DECISIVE ACTIONS:

- Appointed Chancellor by President Hindenburg in March 1930 to bypass the deadlocked Reichstag.
- Imposed severe deflationary cuts to unemployment benefits, civil service salaries, and pensions despite skyrocketing unemployment.
- Dissolved the Reichstag in July 1930, triggering the catastrophic September election where Nazi seats surged from 12 to 107.

ACT 4 THE ELECTORAL BREAKTHROUGH: 230 SEATS AND THE LARGEST PARTY IN THE REICHSTAG (JUL 1932)

[5.1] A vital factor in Nazi success was the violent **work of the SA**. Growing to over 400,000 uniformed stormtroopers by 1932, the SA dominated the streets, protected Nazi meetings, broke up communist gatherings, and intimidated political opponents. In an era of political chaos and parliamentary paralysis, the uniformed discipline and aggressive anti-communist street fighting of the SA convinced millions of middle-class voters that only the Nazis possessed the strength to restore public order.

[5.2] In the **July 1932 election**, these factors produced an astonishing electoral triumph: the Nazi Party won **230 seats (37.3% of the vote)**, becoming by far the largest party in the Reichstag. Although President Hindenburg refused Hitler's demand for the Chancellorship, dismissively calling him a "Bohemian corporal," the combined anti-democratic seats of Nazis and Communists paralyzed the Reichstag, leaving Weimar democracy completely deadlocked.

ELECTORAL MECHANISM: NEGATIVE COHESION MASS MOBILISATION • 1930–1932

Negative Cohesion & The Threat of Communist Revolution

Historians define 'negative cohesion' as people uniting not around shared ideological goals, but around shared hatreds and fears. As unemployment soared to 6 million, the communist KPD gained millions of votes, winning 100 Reichstag seats by November 1932. The German middle class (*Mittelstand*), shopkeepers, farmers, and wealthy industrialists were terrified of a violent Bolshevik revolution that would confiscate their private property. Hitler presented the SA as the only force capable of crushing communist street fighters, winning millions of respectable votes purely as a defensive bulwark against revolution.

Mobilising Fear: The dramatic surge in Nazi votes was driven less by positive enthusiasm for Nazi doctrine than by panic, visceral anti-communism, and disgust with Weimar's democratic paralysis.

HISTORIOGRAPHICAL DEBATE WHY DID MILLIONS VOTE NAZI? ECONOMIC RUIN VS VISCERAL ANTI-COMMUNISM

Interpretation A: Middle-Class Class Panic (Thomas Childers)

"The core of the Nazi electoral constituency was the Protestant middle class, driven to panic by economic liquidation and proletarianization. They voted Nazi because Hitler promised to defend private property and social status."

Interpretation B: Broad Cross-Class Appeal (Richard Bessel)

*"The NSDAP succeeded because it broke traditional class boundaries. It became a 'catch-all party of protest' (*Volkspartei*), uniting unemployed youth, peasant farmers, small shopkeepers, and frightened industrialists under dynamic national leadership."*

KEY CHRONOLOGY • FOUR CAUSAL TURNING POINTS ENQUIRY 2.3 SEQUENCE

24 Oct 1929 • The Wall Street Crash
US banks call in short-term loans; German factories close, banks fail, and mass unemployment begins to surge.

14 Sep 1930 • Reichstag Breakthrough
Nazis leap from 12 to 107 seats, becoming the second-largest party as Brüning imposes deflationary austerity.

Apr 1932 • Presidential Election
Hitler wins 13.4 million votes (36.8%) against Hindenburg, proving massive national support via plane campaign.

31 Jul 1932 • Largest Party in Reichstag
NSDAP wins 230 seats (37.3%) amid 6 million unemployed; Hindenburg refuses to make Hitler Chancellor.

EDEXCEL PAPER 3 EXAMINATION STRATEGY • SECTION B QUESTION 3(a) • 8 MARKS • 12 MINS

Exam Challenge: How useful are Sources B and C for an enquiry into the reasons for the growth of Nazi support in the years 1929–1932? [8 marks]

Specification Technique: Interrogate Content, Provenance (Nature, Origin, Purpose), and Context for both sources before reaching a weighed judgment. **GRADE 9 UTILITY**

KT2.4: How Hitler Became Chancellor, 1932–1933

Key Enquiry: The Backstairs Intrigue: How did secret political scheming, revenge, and a fatal underestimation rescue a struggling Adolf Hitler and hand him the Chancellorship of Germany? • *Sections 1 & 2: Context, Catalysts & Primary Evidence*

ACT 1 THE FALL OF BRÜNING, ECONOMIC DESPAIR & THE DEATH OF DEMOCRACY

[1.1] **Brüning's Austerity & The Collapse of Parliamentary Rule:** By the spring of 1932, parliamentary democracy in Weimar Germany had completely collapsed. Unable to maintain a coalition majority in the Reichstag, Chancellor Heinrich Brüning relied entirely on President Paul von Hindenburg to govern through Article 48 emergency decrees. Brüning's relentless deflationary austerity—slashing unemployment benefits, cutting civil service wages, and raising taxes—worsened the Great Depression, driving unemployment past 6 million and earning him the bitter title of the 'Hunger Chancellor'.

[1.2] **The Ban on the SA and the Fatal Agrarian Miscalculation:** In April 1932, attempting to quell escalating street warfare, Brüning banned the SA and SS, provoking outrage from right-wing nationalists and conservative army generals led by Kurt von Schleicher. Simultaneously, Brüning proposed breaking up bankrupt aristocratic estates in East Prussia to settle unemployed workers. Hindenburg, himself a wealthy Junker landlord, was outraged by this plan, condemning it as "agrarian Bolshevism". Betrayed by Schleicher and abandoned by the President, Brüning was forced to resign on 30 May 1932.

[1.3] **The Preussenschlag & The Summer of Paramilitary Terror:** The lifting of the SA ban in June 1932 triggered widespread political violence, resulting in over 100 street murders in five weeks. In Hamburg, the 'Altona Bloody Sunday' left 18 dead. Papen cynically exploited this disorder to execute the *Preussenschlag* (Prussian coup), declaring martial law and unconstitutionally removing the democratically elected SPD state government of Prussia. By dismantling Prussia's independent police force, Papen destroyed the strongest remaining democratic bulwark against National Socialism.

ACT 2 THE 1932 ELECTIONS & THE BACKSTAIRS INTRIGUE

[2.1] **The 'Cabinet of Barons' and the July 1932 Electoral Triumph:** Hindenburg appointed conservative aristocrat Franz von Papen as Chancellor, heading an unelected aristocratic ministry nicknamed the 'Cabinet of Barons'. Lacking Reichstag support, Papen lifted the ban on the SA and dissolved parliament to hold fresh elections in July 1932. The election was a stunning triumph for the NSDAP: winning 230 seats (37.3% of the vote), the Nazis became the largest party in the Reichstag. Hitler immediately demanded the Chancellorship. However, President Hindenburg, deeply contemptuous of the Austrian-born "Bohemian corporal", flatly refused.

[2.2] **The November 1932 Crisis & Papen's Fatal Deal:** Refusing to cooperate, the Nazis and Communists paralysed parliament, forcing another election in November 1932. Nazi support dropped to 196 seats, while communist votes surged. Terrified of civil war, General Schleicher persuaded Hindenburg to sack Papen and make Schleicher Chancellor in December. Determined to seek revenge, Papen struck a secret deal with Hitler in January 1933: Hitler would become Chancellor in a coalition cabinet where only three of eleven ministers were Nazis, with Papen as Vice-Chancellor with personal right of access to Hindenburg. Papen boastfully assured traditional conservatives: "Within two months, we will have pushed Hitler so far into a corner that he'll squeak!" On 30 January 1933, Hindenburg appointed Adolf Hitler Chancellor of Germany.

[2.3] **The Cologne Villa Deal & Schleicher's Humiliation:** General Schleicher's tenure as Chancellor was brief and disastrous: his attempts to split the Nazi party by offering Gregor Strasser the Vice-Chancellorship collapsed, alienating both Hitler and trade unions. Meanwhile, Papen met Hitler secretly on 4 January 1933 at the Cologne villa of banker Kurt von Schröder. Backed by wealthy industrialists and Hindenburg's inner circle (including the President's son Oskar), Papen persuaded Hindenburg that Hitler could be tightly controlled in a cabinet with only two other Nazis (Göring and Frick), sealing the fate of the Republic.

SOURCE A ARCHIVAL PHOTOGRAPH 21 March 1933

Vice-Chancellor Franz von Papen and Chancellor Adolf Hitler on Potsdam Day



Vice-Chancellor Franz von Papen walking in top hat and tails alongside newly appointed Chancellor Adolf Hitler outside the Potsdam Garrison Church. Papen famously reassured conservative allies: "We have hired him for our own purposes... In two months' time, we will have pushed Hitler so far into a corner that he'll squeak!"

HINGE QUESTION: *How does this photograph and Papen's private boast demonstrate the fatal miscalculation of Germany's traditional conservative elites?*

SOURCE B PRESIDENTIAL STATEMENT 13 August 1932

President Paul von Hindenburg to Adolf Hitler

> *"His Excellency the Reich President declared that he could not reconcile it with his conscience and his duties to the Fatherland to transfer the entire governing power to the National Socialist movement alone, which wished to use this power in a one-sided manner. He regretted that Herr Hitler saw himself unable to support a national government headed by Chancellor von Papen."*

Hindenburg's frosty rejection of Hitler's demand for the Chancellorship following the July 1932 elections, highlighting the 84-year-old Field Marshal's deep aristocratic contempt for the Austrian-born "Bohemian corporal".

HINGE QUESTION: *What factors forced President Hindenburg to reverse his vehement refusal and appoint Hitler Chancellor just five months later?*

CORE DISCIPLINARY TERMINOLOGY • ENQUIRY 2.4 — EDEXCEL PAPER 3 VOCABULARY

BACKSTAIRS INTRIGUE
Secret aristocratic negotiations between Papen, Schleicher, and Hindenburg to bypass the Reichstag and appoint Hitler.

FRANZ VON PAPEN
Conservative aristocrat who persuaded Hindenburg to appoint Hitler Chancellor, falsely believing he could control him.

KURT VON SCHLEICHER
Army general and Chancellor (Dec 1932–Jan 1933) whose failed intrigue against Papen paved the way for Hitler's appointment.

30 JANUARY 1933
The date Adolf Hitler was formally sworn in as Chancellor of Germany by President Paul von Hindenburg.

KT2.4: How Hitler Became Chancellor, 1932–1933

ACT 3 THE BACKSTAIRS CONSPIRACY: TRICKING PRESIDENT HINDENBURG INTO SQUEEZING HITLER INTO A CORNER (JAN 1933)

[4.1] Over late January 1933, the definitive **reasons for Hitler becoming Chancellor in 1933** centered on political intrigue orchestrated by Franz von Papen. President Hindenburg intensely disliked Hitler and initially refused to appoint him. However, Papen allied with the President's son, Major Oskar von Hindenburg, and presidential secretary Otto Meissner, convincing the senile Field Marshal that appointing Hitler was the only constitutional way to avoid civil war and military collapse.

[4.2] Papen famously assured Hindenburg that the conservative aristocracy would retain total control: *"Within two months, we will have **pushed Hitler into a corner** so far that he'll squeak!"* (**Source A**). The proposed cabinet contained eleven ministers, but only three Nazis: Hitler as Chancellor, Wilhelm Frick as Interior Minister, and Hermann Göring as Minister without Portfolio. Papen, as Vice-Chancellor, possessed the right to attend every presidential meeting, convincing conservative elites they had safely boxed Hitler in and squeezed into a corner to corner Hitler.

PRESIDENTIAL COMMUNIQUÉ OFFICIAL CHANCELLERY RECORD — 30 January 1933

The Appointment of Adolf Hitler as Chancellor

"At 11:15 this morning, the Reich President Herr Field Marshal von Hindenburg swore in Adolf Hitler as Reich Chancellor. Herr von Papen took the oath as Vice-Chancellor. The President expressed his hope that the new government of national concentration will successfully restore internal peace and economic strength to the Fatherland."

KEY HISTORICAL INDIVIDUAL — 1879–1969



Franz von Papen
CHANCELLOR OF GERMANY (1932) & VICE-CHANCELLOR UNDER HITLER (1933–1934)

Aristocratic politician who persuaded President Hindenburg to appoint Hitler Chancellor in January 1933, arrogantly claiming he had "boxed Hitler into a corner".

DECISIVE ACTIONS:

- Appointed Chancellor in June 1932, leading an aristocratic "Cabinet of Barons" with virtually zero Reichstag support.
- Toppled the democratic SPD government of Prussia in July 1932 (*Preussenschlag*), destroying Germany's strongest republican bulwark.
- Formed a secret pact with Hitler in January 1933 to oust Kurt von Schleicher, agreeing to a coalition with only three Nazi cabinet ministers.

ACT 4 TORCHES THROUGH THE BRANDENBURG GATE: ADOLF HITLER APPOINTED CHANCELLOR (30 JAN 1933)

[5.1] On the morning of Monday, 30 January 1933, Adolf Hitler was formally sworn in by President Hindenburg as Chancellor of the German Republic (**Source B**). Hitler had achieved executive power through constitutional legality, without firing a shot. The traditional conservative elites congratulated themselves on having co-opted the mass Nazi movement to serve their own nationalist restoration.

[5.2] That night, the illusion of conservative control shattered. Over 25,000 uniformed SA and SS men staged a triumphant, synchronized torchlight procession through the Brandenburg Gate, singing martial anthems as Hitler watched from the Chancellery window. From Munich, retired General Ludendorff sent a prophetic warning telegram to President Hindenburg: *"I solemnly prophesy that this accursed man will cast our Reich into the abyss and bring our nation to inconceivable misery. Future generations will damn you in your grave for what you have done."*

POLITICAL MECHANISM: THE BACKSTAIRS PLOT — THE SEIZURE OF POWER • JANUARY 1933

The Aristocratic Conspiracy & The Fatal Miscalculation

By November 1932, the Nazi Party was in severe crisis: it lost 2 million votes and 34 Reichstag seats, running out of funds. Chancellor Kurt von Schleicher attempted to split the party by offering the vice-chancellorship to Gregor Strasser. Terrified of being sidelined, Franz von Papen met Hitler secretly at the home of Cologne banker Kurt von Schröder on 4 January 1933. Papen convinced President Hindenburg that the only way to establish a stable right-wing government was to make Hitler Chancellor, with Papen as Vice-Chancellor and conservative nationalists holding eight out of eleven cabinet posts. Papen famously boasted: "Within two months, we will have pushed Hitler into a corner until he squeaks!"

Pushed into Power: Hitler did not seize power through an armed march on Berlin or an electoral majority; he was invited into the Chancellery by conservative elites who mistakenly believed they could control him.

HISTORIOGRAPHICAL DEBATE HOW DID HITLER BECOME CHANCELLOR? POPULAR MANDATE OR ELITE INTRIGUE?

Interpretation A: Aristocratic Intrigue (Alan Bullock)
"Hitler did not take power by storm; he was hoisted into office by a backstairs intrigue between Papen, Oskar von Hindenburg, and Otto Meissner. Without their fatal miscalculation, Hitler would never have gained the Chancellorship."

Interpretation B: Democratic Vacuum (Ian Kershaw)
"Intrigue alone cannot explain 1933. Papen and Hindenburg turned to Hitler only because parliamentary democracy had completely collapsed and the Nazis commanded the largest mass movement in German history."

KEY CHRONOLOGY • FOUR CAUSAL TURNING POINTS — ENQUIRY 2.4 SEQUENCE

30 May 1932 • Brüning Sacked by Hindenburg
Hindenburg dismisses Brüning over East Prussian land reforms; appoints Franz von Papen to lead the "Barons".

6 Nov 1932 • Nazi Electoral Setback
NSDAP loses 34 seats and party funds run dry; General von Schleicher replaces Papen as Chancellor in December.

4 Jan 1933 • Cologne Villa Conspiracy
Papen meets Hitler secretly at banker Schröder's villa, plotting to oust Schleicher by offering Hitler power.

30 Jan 1933 • Hitler Appointed Chancellor
Hindenburg appoints Hitler Chancellor in an 11-man cabinet with only 3 Nazis; Papen claims Hitler is "boxed in".

EDEXCEL PAPER 3 EXAMINATION STRATEGY • SECTION B — QUESTION 3(d) • 16 MARKS + 4 SPaG • 25 MINS

Exam Challenge: How far do you agree with Interpretation 2 about how Hitler became Chancellor in 1932–33? Explain your answer, using both interpretations and your knowledge of the historical context. [16 marks]

Specification Technique: Weigh Interpretation 1 against Interpretation 2; deploy precise contextual evidence; sustain a criteria-led historical verdict. **GRADE 9 VERDICT**

KEY TOPIC 2 REVISION SPINE: CORE KNOWLEDGE & EXAM STRATEGY

Pearson Edexcel GCSE (9–1) History • Paper 3 Option 31 (1HI0/31)

1. KEY CHRONOLOGY • CAUSAL TURNING POINTS

KEY CHRONOLOGY

5 Jan 1919: DAP Founded in Munich: Anton Drexler establishes party; Hitler joins as military intelligence agent in Sep 1919.

24 Feb 1920: 25-Point Programme: Hitler proclaims manifesto at Hofbräuhaus; party renamed National Socialist (NSDAP).

29 Jul 1921: Hitler Becomes Führer: Hitler ousts Drexler, demanding absolute dictatorial control over party organization.

4 Nov 1921: SA Officially Established: Ernst Röhm organizes Brownshirt paramilitary squad to intimidate political opponents.

8–9 Nov 1923: The Munich Putsch: Hitler attempts armed coup in Bavaria; 16 Nazis killed at Feldherrnhalle; Hitler jailed.

Feb–Dec 1924: Landsberg Imprisonment: Hitler turns trial into propaganda triumph; writes *Mein Kampf*; adopts legal strategy.

14 Feb 1926: Bamberg Party Conference: Hitler defeats northern socialist faction (Goebbels/Strasser); reasserts Führerprinzip.

20 May 1928: Reichstag Election Failure: Golden Twenties prosperity reduces Nazi vote to just 2.6% (12 seats) nationally.

29 Oct 1929: Wall Street Crash: US banks recall short-term loans; German factories close; unemployment surges toward 6M.

14 Sep 1930: Reichstag Breakthrough: Amid economic panic, Nazi vote surges eightfold to 18.3% (107 seats), becoming 2nd largest party.

31 Jul 1932: Peak Nazi Electoral Triumph: Nazis win 37.3% (230 seats) to become largest party; Hindenburg refuses Hitler Chancellorship.

30 Jan 1933: Hitler Appointed Chancellor: Papen and Hindenburg agree backstairs deal, mistakenly believing they can control Hitler.

2. CORE SPECIFICATION THEMES

SPECIFICATION REVIEW

I. EARLY IDEOLOGY & PARAMILITARY VIOLENCE

The 25-Point Programme fused militant nationalism, anti-Versailles revanchism, and racial antisemitism. Ernst Röhm's SA provided street-level muscle, violently silencing political opponents and creating an image of dynamic militarism.

II. THE MUNICH PUTSCH & LEGAL STRATEGY

The 1923 coup failure proved the state could not be seized by force. In Landsberg Prison, Hitler formulated the legal strategy: utilizing democratic elections to dismantle democracy from within, while building a nationwide Gauleiter network.

III. GREAT DEPRESSION & MASS MOBILISATION

The Wall Street Crash wiped out 6 million jobs. Heinrich Brüning's austerity dismantled parliamentary rule. Hitler capitalized on "negative cohesion"—uniting frightened middle-class voters terrified of a communist Bolshevik revolution.

IV. CONSERVATIVE BACKSTAIRS INTRIGUE

Despite losing 2 million votes in November 1932, Hitler was handed power by Franz von Papen and conservative elites. Their arrogant delusion that they could "box Hitler into a corner" was the fatal catalyst that destroyed the Republic.

3. HISTORIOGRAPHICAL DEBATE & EDEXCEL PAPER 3 EXAMINATION STRATEGY

EXAM STRATEGY • Q3(B,C,D)

INTERPRETATION 1: THE MASTER DEMAGOGUE (ALAN BULLOCK)

Hitler was an unprincipled political opportunist of genius who combined theatrical oratory, ruthless tactical flexibility, and cynical exploitation of German grievances to manipulate both the masses and conservative elites into giving him power.

INTERPRETATION 2: CIRCUMSTANCE & CHARISMATIC MOBILISATION (IAN KERSHAW)

Hitler was not an all-powerful puppet master. His rise was made possible because the Great Depression created a total systemic collapse of Weimar institutions, allowing his radical message to resonate with millions seeking salvation.

Q1: INFERENCE [4m]	Q2: CAUSATION [12m]	Q3(a): UTILITY [8m]	Q3(b/c): VIEWS [8m]	Q3(d): VERDICT [16+4m]
5 Mins • 2 Inferences + Quotes	15 Mins • 3 PEEL Causal Factors	12 Mins • Content, NOP & Context	10 Mins • Differences & Reasons	25 Mins • Balanced Evaluation

4. SYNOPTIC ASSESSMENT • HISTORICAL VERDICT

EVALUATION & SIGNIFICANCE

IDEOLOGICAL APPEAL VS ECONOMIC DESPAIR:
Nazi ideology remained essentially unchanged between 1924 and 1928, yet voters overwhelmingly rejected it (2.6%). Only when the Great Depression destroyed economic security and pushed 6 million into unemployment did Hitler's radical messianism find mass traction.

THE ROLE OF NEGATIVE COHESION:
Hitler's electoral surge was fueled primarily by negative cohesion: voters united not by love of Nazi ideology, but by visceral hatred of Versailles, contempt for democratic coalition paralysis, and terrified panic over communist revolution.

THE BACKSTAIRS ABDICATION OF ELITES:
Hitler did not win an electoral majority; by late 1932, Nazi support was declining. He became Chancellor because aristocratic conservative elites (Papen, Hindenburg, Meissner) actively conspired to subvert democracy, believing they could tame him.

5. INTERACTIVE QUIZZING HUB • SCAN WITH SMARTPHONE CAMERA

20-QUESTION PRACTICE QUIZZES

KT2.1
Early Nazi Party (1919–22)

INTERACTIVE HUB • QUIZ

KT2.2
Putsch & Lean Years

INTERACTIVE HUB • QUIZ

KT2.3
Growth of Support (1929–32)

INTERACTIVE HUB • QUIZ

KT2.4
Hitler Becomes Chancellor

INTERACTIVE HUB • QUIZ